

The FAIR+ Cheat Sheet for Research Teams

A Guide to Collaborative Data Management

F — Findable

If you can't find it, it doesn't exist.

- **Metadata:** Data about the data. Does the file name `Dataset_V2_Final_ActualFinal.csv` mean anything to a teammate six months from now?
- **Persistent Identifiers (PIDs):** Assigning a DOI or a unique ID so the data can be cited and located regardless of where it's moved.
- **Searchability:** Is the data indexed in a place where your team (and the public, if required) can search for it?

A — Accessible

Knowing it exists isn't the same as being able to open it.

- **Authentication:** Who has the "key"? Define the specific protocols (e.g., VPN, login credentials) required to reach the data.
- **Long-term Availability:** If the PI's lab website goes down, where does the data live? (e.g., Institutional repositories like Zenodo or Dryad).
- **Open vs. Restricted:** "Accessible" doesn't always mean "Free for everyone." It means the *process* for requesting access is clear and automated.

I — Interoperable

Data should play well with others.

- **Machine-Readable:** Can a computer program (like an AI tool) ingest the data without a human having to manually re-format 1,000 PDFs?
- **Shared Vocabulary:** Does everyone on the team agree on what "Age" means? (e.g., Is it "Age at birth," "Age at enrollment," or "Age in months"?)
- **Non-Proprietary Formats:** Favoring `.csv` or `.json` over formats that require expensive, specialized software (like `.sas7bdat` or proprietary AI files).

R — Reusable

Build for the future, not just the deadline.

- **Documentation (The "Readme"):** Does the data include a "User Manual" that explains the variables, the methodology, and the limitations?
- **Licensing:** Using clear licenses (like Creative Commons) so others know exactly how they are allowed to use, credit, or remix your work.

+ — The "Plus" (Secure & Ethical)

FAIR is great; safe is better.

- **De-identification:** Ensuring human subject data is stripped of identifiers (HIPAA compliance).
- **Trust & Sovereignty:** Respecting the rights of communities (like the Clinic in our scenario) to control how their data is used, even if the data is "technically" findable.
- **Sustainability:** Ensuring the data remains secure and usable long after the grant funding ends.

The Team Science Tip: Data sharing is 20% technical and 80% cultural. Use these principles to build **Psychological Safety**—when everyone knows the rules, they are more likely to share their best work.